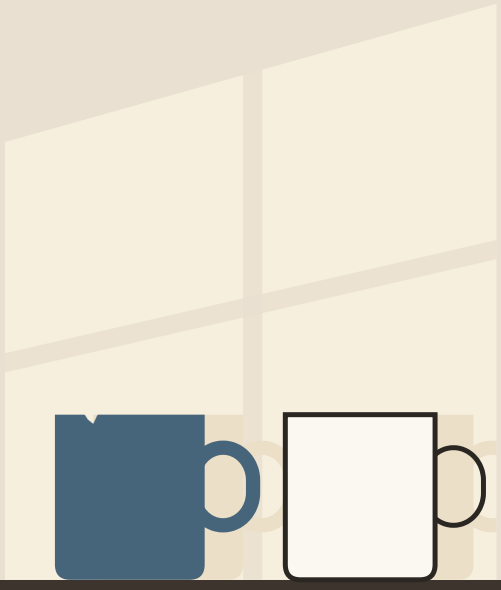
The Shape *of* Ordinary Days

A Fictional Memoir of Recovery and Return



ALEX MORGAN

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ÉLITE PUBLISHING

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CHAPTER ONE



The Lower Shelf

THE KEY STUCK the way it always had, half a turn and then nothing, and Nell said, "Let me," and I said, "I've got it," and for a while we stood on the front step with my hand on the key and hers held an inch above it, not quite touching.

The trick is to lift the door by the handle as you turn. I had known that for eleven years. It took me three tries to remember it.

Inside, the first thing was the smell. Not a bad one—radiator dust, the cedar block in the coat closet, something faintly like oranges—just the smell of my own house, which I had apparently never noticed while I was living in it. I stood in the hall and breathed it in and felt, absurdly, like a guest.

"Do you want to sit down?" Nell said.

"I've been sitting down since February."

"That isn't an answer."

It wasn't. There was a bench by the door that hadn't been there before, a low pine thing with a cushion tied on at the corners, placed exactly where I would stand to take off my shoes. I looked at it. Nell watched me look at it.

"It was forty dollars," she said. "You're allowed to hate it."

"I don't hate it."

I sat on it. My shoes were the ones I'd been wearing the day I left, and somebody—Nell—had cleaned them. The laces were new. I undid them slowly, partly because my hands were slow and partly because I didn't want to stand up again just yet in front of her, and she knew that, and went into

the kitchen to make a noise with the kettle so I could do it without an audience.

That is the kind of sister she is. It is also the kind of sister she is that she called out, "Take your time!" from the kitchen, which undid most of the good.

THE HOUSE HAD been kept beautifully, and it was not quite mine.

The mail was stacked on the hall table in four bundles, one for each month, each with a rubber band and a yellow sticky note: *February*, *March*, *April*, *May*. The plant on the windowsill—a pothos I had been failing to kill for years—had been watered so faithfully that it had put out a new vine and trained it along the curtain rail. The fridge held foods I don't buy: oat milk, a bag of washed spinach, little pots of yogurt with names like *Orchard*. The calendar on the kitchen wall still said February. Nell hadn't turned it. I didn't know whether that was tact or superstition, and I didn't turn it either.

"I'll stay till the end of the month," Nell said. She had her back to me, pouring water. "Work's fine about it. Graham's fine about it."

"You don't have to."

"I know I don't have to."

"I just mean you've already—"

"I know what you mean."

What I meant, I think, was two things at once. I meant: go home, back to your own kitchen and the husband you've been talking to on speakerphone since winter, so that I can find out what I'm like when nobody is watching. And I meant: please don't. I couldn't have said which was louder. She put a cup of tea in front of me, in a white mug she must have brought from home, and sat down across the table with hers, and we drank them, and neither of us said anything else about it.

MY FRIEND THEO called at four.

"You're home," he said. "How is it? How are you feeling?"

"Good," I said. "Really good. It's strange, but a good strange. It's very quiet."

All of that was true, the way a postcard is true. I was sitting on the bottom stair because it was the nearest place to sit when the phone rang, and while we talked I had been looking at the other thirteen and thinking about them in a way I had never thought about stairs. Not with fear. More the way you might look at a long sentence in a language you used to speak well.

"You sound tired," Theo said.

"I'm on the stairs," I said, as if that explained it, and he laughed, and I laughed, and he told me about a man at his office who had started bringing a standing desk to meetings, and I said all the right things in the right places. When we hung up I stayed where I was. Then I went up, one hand on the rail, and at the top I sat down on the landing carpet, which is not a thing adults do in their own homes, and waited until I was ready for whatever came next.

Nell found me there on her way to the bathroom.

"Oh," she said.

"I'm just sitting."

"Okay." She stepped over my legs, carefully, and then stopped and came back and sat down beside me, her knees up near her chin the way she used to sit when we were children watching television through the banisters. She didn't ask anything. After a minute she said, "This carpet is disgusting, by the way," and I said, "I know," and that was, somehow, the best conversation I'd had all day.

THE MUGS WERE the thing that went wrong.

It was early evening. Nell was in the backyard on the phone to Graham, walking up and down the path, and I decided I would make the tea. It seemed a manageable ambition. I filled the kettle—the kettle was where it lived—and switched it on, and then I reached up to the cabinet above the toaster, where my mugs had been since the day I moved in, and opened it, and found cans of soup.

The mugs were in the cabinet under the counter, on the lower shelf, lined up in two rows with their handles all facing the same way. So were the plates. So were the teapot and the honey and the tea itself. Everything I used every day had come down to waist height, and everything I didn't—the soup, the good glasses, a fondue set someone gave me years ago—had gone up.

I stood there with the cabinet door open for long enough that the kettle clicked off.

"You moved the mugs," I said when she came in.

She looked at the open cabinet, and then at me, and I watched her decide how to answer.

"I moved the things you use."

"I didn't ask you to."

"No," she said. "You weren't really in a position to be asked."

It came out sharper than she meant. I saw it reach her own face a second after it reached mine. She put her phone down on the counter.

"Sorry. That was—"

"It's fine."

"It isn't. I just thought, the first few weeks, you wouldn't want to be stretching up for things. I don't know. I read something."

"I can reach a cabinet, Nell."

"I know you can."

Neither of us knew that. That was the problem, underneath the mugs. I didn't know yet what I could do. For months, people had told me what I could do—sit up, stand, walk to the window, walk to the end of the corridor and back—and now I was home, where no one was going to tell me anything, and the first thing I'd found was that my sister had already guessed. She had guessed low. She might have been right.

Nell made the tea in the end. I let her.

THAT NIGHT I couldn't sleep, which everyone had warned me about, though not in a way that helped. The bed was too wide and the room was too dark, and the quiet pressed on my ears. For months I'd had a door that never quite

Design notes

THE COVER

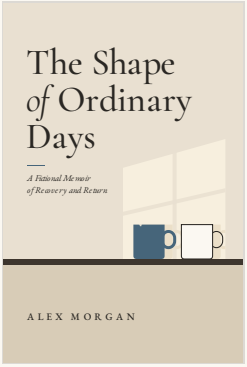
The cover is built from the book's own material rather than stock imagery. Two mugs stand on a low shelf, handles turned the same way, in the slanted light of a kitchen window: details taken from the first chapter. There are no hospital images or symbols of transformation. The story is about returning to ordinary life, so the cover shows ordinary life, closely observed.

TYPE AND COLOR

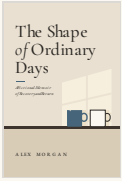
The title is set in Cormorant Garamond, a display serif with long, calm strokes; the text is EB Garamond, a classic book face made for reading at length. The palette is limited to warm oat, window light, ink and one muted blue, the narrator's chipped mug, which returns inside the book as the only accent.

THE INTERIOR

Pages are 6 × 9 inches with mirrored margins and a deeper foot. Text is justified on a 15-point baseline with controlled hyphenation, and pages are balanced to avoid widows and orphans. Running heads carry the book title on left-hand pages and the chapter title on right-hand pages, and are dropped on display pages. Chapters open low on the page with small capitals and a reduced shelf motif, so the reader enters each one quietly, as the story does.



1.25 in wide



0.6 in

The title holds the top third of the cover in large, high-contrast type, so it stays legible as a small thumbnail.

Trim size	6 × 9 in, portrait
Text	EB Garamond 11/15 pt, justified
Display	Cormorant Garamond
Margins	Inside 0.875 in, outside 0.625 in, top 0.83 in, foot 1.08 in
Folios	Foot, centered; omitted on display pages